



A NUTRITION REFERENCE FOR THE INDIAN PLATE

What's Actually in Your Thali



Calories & Micronutrients of 250+ Indian Foods —
serving by serving, region by region,
with the numbers that actually matter.



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IFCT 2017 · NIN Hyderabad
USDA FoodData Central

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255

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BY HOUSEHOLD SERVING

5

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50

PAGES, FULLY
CROSS-REFERENCED

DETAILED INDEX

Every category, by region

Each region runs in the same order — grains first, then dals, vegetables, dairy, non-veg, fermented foods, snacks, sweets and drinks — so the same food type always sits in the same place, whichever part of the country you turn to.

North India from p. 6

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THREE WAYS TO USE THIS INDEX

By meal

Turn to your region and read the categories in the order you serve them — staple, dal, vegetable, side.

By nutrient

Skip to the Quick Reference Charts on page 48, where every food in the book is ranked by iron, protein, calcium and fibre.

By question

Nutrition Myths, Busted (page 47) answers the twelve claims that send most readers looking for a table in the first place.

INTRODUCTION

The thali is the diet. Nobody ever measured it.

Almost every nutrition table an Indian reader can find was built around food that Indians do not eat. Cups of cereal, ounces of cheese, grams of raw broccoli. Meanwhile the actual meal — two rotis, a katori of dal, a spoon of ghee, a glass of chai — goes uncounted.

This book counts it. Every entry here is a household serving: one medium roti, one katori, one glass, one piece. The values behind those servings come from the Indian Food Composition Tables 2017, the National Institute of Nutrition's measurement of 528 Indian foods across six regions, with USDA FoodData Central used only where IFCT has no entry for a composite dish.

What emerges is not a list of good foods and bad foods. It is a set of trade-offs. Spinach carries iron your body can barely reach. Mutton carries iron it absorbs three times as well. Chai steals iron from the meal it follows. Ghee unlocks vitamins that greens would otherwise waste. None of that fits on a label, and all of it changes what your plate actually delivers.

What this book is not

It is not a diet plan, and it prescribes nothing. Serving sizes here describe how Indian households actually eat, not how anyone should. Requirements differ by age, sex, pregnancy, activity and disease — a clinician or registered dietitian is the person to translate these numbers into a plan for one particular body.

A NOTE ON PRECISION

Cooked food is not a laboratory sample. Oil absorbed while frying, the size of your katori, how long the saag simmered and whose hand added the ghee will all move these numbers by 10–20%. Read every figure here as a well-anchored estimate for a typical home-style preparation, not a measurement of the plate in front of you.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

Reading a data card

Every food in this book is presented the same way, so you can compare a Punjabi breakfast with a Tamil one without re-learning the layout.



Phulka / Chapati
whole wheat roti, no oil

1 medium (40 g atta)

 104 KCAL	PROTEIN 3.4g	CARBS 20.5g	FAT 0.8g	FIBRE 2.6g
 Magnesium 50 mg	 Iron 1.5 mg	 Zinc 0.9 mg		

Wheat iron is non-heme and partly locked up by phytate. A squeeze of lemon or a vitamin-C rich salad alongside can multiply how much you absorb.

The four things on every card

The serving — a household measure, not 100 g. One katori is taken as 150 g of cooked food, one glass as 200 ml.

The calorie block — kilocalories for that serving, cooking fat included.

The macros — protein, carbohydrate, fat and dietary fibre in grams.

Key micronutrients — only the three that matter most in that food, not an exhaustive list. The full IFCT profile runs to 150 nutrients; three is what you can use.

THE INSIGHT LINE

The italic line closing each card is the part you cannot get from a table: an absorption trick, a deficiency risk, or a widely repeated claim checked against the data.

MICRONUTRIENT ICONS

- | | |
|--|---|
|  Iron |  Calcium |
|  B-vitamins |  Folate |
|  Vitamin A |  Vitamin C |
|  Vitamin D |  Magnesium |
|  Zinc |  Potassium |
|  Sodium |  Selenium |

THE MEASURES USED IN THIS BOOK

150 g

1 KATORI
COOKED DAL, SABZI OR
RICE

200 ml

1 GLASS
MILK, LASSI OR CHAAS

40 g

1 MEDIUM ROTI
ATTA BEFORE COOKING

5 g

1 TEASPOON
GHEE, OIL OR SUGAR

Where a dish is cooked with fat, a household quantity is assumed and stated on the card — so the calories you read include the oil in the pan, not just the vegetable in it. Values are rounded; totals may not add up to the calorie figure exactly.



REGION ONE

North India

A wheat-and-dairy belt: more protein and calcium than most Indian regions, and more fat with it. The recurring risks here are iron that phytate keeps locked away, refined flour standing in for whole grain, and cooking fat quietly doubling the calories of a vegetable.



Grains & Staples

Phulka / Chapati, Bajra Roti, Makki di Roti, Boiled Rice

Vegetables

Sarson da Saag, Palak, Aloo, boiled, Baingan Bharta

Non-Veg

Tandoori Chicken, Chicken Curry, Mutton Curry, Rohu Fish Curry

Dals & Legumes

Arhar / Toor Dal, Chana Dal, Moong Dal, Rajma

Dairy

Paneer, Buffalo Milk, Dahi, Sweet Lassi

Snacks, Sweets & Beverages

Aloo Paratha, Samosa, Gajar ka Halwa, Jalebi





Phulka / Chapati

whole wheat roti, no oil

1 medium (40 g atta)

104
KCAL

PROTEIN
3.4g

CARBS
20.5g

FAT
0.8g

FIBRE
2.6g

Magnesium

50 mg

Iron

1.5 mg

Zinc

0.9 mg

Wheat iron is non-heme and partly locked up by phytate. A squeeze of lemon or a vitamin-C rich salad alongside can multiply how much you absorb.



Bajra Roti

pearl millet · sajjje · kambu

1 roti (45 g flour)

158
KCAL

PROTEIN
4.7g

CARBS
28g

FAT
2.2g

FIBRE
5g

Iron

2.9 mg

Magnesium

62 mg

Zinc

1.4 mg

Roughly twice the iron and double the fibre of the same weight of wheat – the cheapest upgrade on a North Indian plate.



Makki di Roti

maize flour roti

1 roti (50 g flour)

178
KCAL

PROTEIN
4.6g

CARBS
32g

FAT
2g

FIBRE
4g

Magnesium

63 mg

Iron

1.3 mg

Vitamin A

45 µg RAE

Eaten with sarson da saag it becomes one of the few traditional pairings that delivers vitamin A, iron and fibre in a single sitting.



Boiled Rice

polished basmati · chawal

1 katori cooked (150 g)

195
KCAL

PROTEIN
4g

CARBS
43g

FAT
0.4g

FIBRE
0.6g

Magnesium

18 mg

Thiamin

0.05 mg

Potassium

55 mg

Polishing strips most of the thiamin and fibre. Rice is not the villain – rice eaten without dal, curd or vegetables is.



Tandoori Naan

maida flatbread

1 piece (90 g)

262
KCAL

PROTEIN
7.5g

CARBS
47g

FAT
4.5g

FIBRE
1.8g

Sodium

380 mg

Calcium

45 mg

Folate

40 µg

Refined flour, so the fibre is a third of a roti's and the sodium is high. Treat it as a restaurant food, not a daily staple.



Arhar / Toor Dal

pigeon pea · tuvar

1 katori cooked (150 g)

105
KCAL

PROTEIN
6.5g

CARBS
17g

FAT
0.7g

FIBRE
4.5g

Folate

90 µg

Magnesium

45 mg

Iron

1.0 mg

Dal is short on methionine, rice is short on lysine. Eaten together they complete each other's protein – the reason dal-chawal outlived every diet trend.



Chana Dal

split Bengal gram

1 katori cooked (150 g)

165
KCAL

PROTEIN
8.7g

CARBS
27g

FAT
2g

FIBRE
6.5g

Folate

120 µg

Iron

1.8 mg

Magnesium

60 mg

One of the lowest-glycaemic staples in the Indian kitchen – the fibre and protein together blunt the sugar rise from whatever it is eaten with.



Moong Dal

yellow split green gram

1 katori cooked (150 g)

130
KCAL

PROTEIN
8.4g

CARBS
22g

FAT
0.6g

FIBRE
3.5g

Folate

110 µg

Potassium

320 mg

Magnesium

45 mg

The most easily digested dal, which is why it is the standard convalescence food – low fat, low oligosaccharide, high protein per calorie.



Rajma

red kidney beans

1 katori cooked (150 g)

155
KCAL

PROTEIN
9.5g

CARBS
26g

FAT
0.7g

FIBRE
8g

Iron

2.4 mg

Folate

175 µg

Potassium

500 mg

Soak overnight and throw the water away: it cuts the phytate that blocks iron and zinc, and most of the gas-forming sugars go with it.



Kala Chana

brown chickpea · Bengal gram whole

1 katori boiled (150 g)

246
KCAL

PROTEIN
13g

CARBS
41g

FAT
2.6g

FIBRE
11g

Iron

4.3 mg

Folate

260 µg

Zinc

2.3 mg

A single katori covers about a fifth of an adult woman's daily iron need and nearly half the day's fibre target. Sprouting it raises both further.



Sarson da Saag

mustard greens, cooked

1 katori (150 g, 1 tsp ghee)

120
KCAL

PROTEIN
4.5g

CARBS
8g

FAT
7g

FIBRE
5g

Vitamin A **690 µg RAE**

Calcium **180 mg**

Iron **2.2 mg**

The ghee is not indulgence, it is chemistry – vitamins A and K in greens are fat-soluble and largely wasted without some fat in the pan.



Palak

spinach, cooked

1 katori (150 g)

55
KCAL

PROTEIN
4g

CARBS
5g

FAT
2.5g

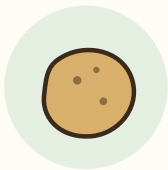
FIBRE
3g

Iron **2.6 mg**

Vitamin A **570 µg RAE**

Folate **90 µg**

The Popeye myth: spinach iron is non-heme and bound to oxalate, so only a small fraction is absorbed. Good food – just not an iron cure.



Aloo, boiled

potato

1 medium (120 g)

100
KCAL

PROTEIN
2.2g

CARBS
22g

FAT
0.1g

FIBRE
2g

Potassium **480 mg**

Vitamin C **12 mg**

Vitamin B6 **0.3 mg**

Boiled and cooled, some of its starch turns resistant – it behaves more like fibre. Deep-fried, the same potato triples its calories.



Baingan Bharta

roasted aubergine

1 katori (150 g, 2 tsp oil)

150
KCAL

PROTEIN
2.5g

CARBS
12g

FAT
11g

FIBRE
4.5g

Potassium **320 mg**

Folate **30 µg**

Manganese **0.3 mg**

Aubergine is 25 kcal per katori; the other 125 come from the oil it soaks up. The vegetable is rarely the problem.



Gobhi Sabzi

cauliflower, dry

1 katori (150 g, 1.5 tsp oil)

110
KCAL

PROTEIN
3g

CARBS
7g

FAT
8g

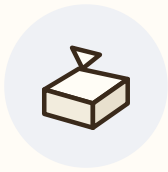
FIBRE
3g

Vitamin C **45 mg**

Vitamin K **18 µg**

Folate **55 µg**

Vitamin C is heat- and water-sensitive. A brief, covered cook keeps most of it; a long simmer in an open pan loses over half.



Paneer

fresh cottage cheese

50 g (4 cubes)

148
KCAL

PROTEIN
9.2g

CARBS
1g

FAT
12g

FIBRE
0g

■ Calcium

240 mg

⚡ Vitamin B12

0.4 µg

🏠 Phosphorus

160 mg

For a vegetarian this is the rare food carrying complete protein, calcium and B12 at once. It is also 70% fat by calories – portion, not principle, is the issue.



Buffalo Milk

full cream, boiled

1 glass (200 ml)

194
KCAL

PROTEIN
8.6g

CARBS
10g

FAT
13.6g

FIBRE
0g

■ Calcium

420 mg

⚡ Vitamin B12

0.7 µg

⚡ Riboflavin

0.2 mg

Nearly half an adult's daily calcium in one glass – but also more fat than two teaspoons of ghee. Cow's milk carries about two-thirds the calories.



Dahi

curd, whole milk

1 katori (150 g)

90
KCAL

PROTEIN
5g

CARBS
7g

FAT
4.8g

FIBRE
0g

■ Calcium

180 mg

⚡ Vitamin B12

0.5 µg

⚡ Riboflavin

0.2 mg

Fermentation lowers the lactose, which is why many who react to milk manage curd. Its calcium does, however, compete with iron – keep it away from your iron meal.



Sweet Lassi

sweetened curd drink

1 glass (200 ml)

180
KCAL

PROTEIN
5g

CARBS
25g

FAT
5g

FIBRE
0g

■ Calcium

200 mg

⚡ Vitamin B12

0.4 µg

⚡ Potassium

260 mg

About four teaspoons of added sugar per glass. Salted lassi or plain chaas keeps the calcium and the probiotics without the sugar load.



Ghee

clarified butter

1 tsp (5 g)

45
KCAL

PROTEIN
0g

CARBS
0g

FAT
5g

FIBRE
0g

🟡 Vitamin A

17 µg RAE

🟢 Vitamin K2

traces

🟢 Vitamin E

0.2 mg

Stable at Indian cooking temperatures and a genuine carrier for fat-soluble vitamins – but still nine calories a gram. A spoon is food; a ladle is a myth.



Tandoori Chicken

breast, skinless

100 g cooked

165
KCAL

PROTEIN
27g

CARBS
2g

FAT
5.5g

FIBRE
0g

⚡ Vitamin B12

0.3 µg

🍷 Selenium

25 µg

🏠 Phosphorus

210 mg

Grilled rather than fried, it is the densest protein-per-calorie item in this book – 27 g of complete protein for the calories of two rotis.



Chicken Curry

home-style, skinless

1 katori (150 g)

235
KCAL

PROTEIN
24g

CARBS
5g

FAT
13g

FIBRE
0.5g

💎 Zinc

2.0 mg

⚡ Vitamin B12

0.6 µg

🩸 Iron

1.5 mg

Removing the skin before cooking cuts roughly 40 kcal per serving without touching the protein.



Mutton Curry

goat meat, bone-in

1 katori (150 g)

280
KCAL

PROTEIN
22g

CARBS
4g

FAT
19g

FIBRE
0.5g

🩸 Iron

2.8 mg

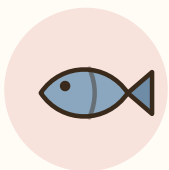
⚡ Vitamin B12

1.8 µg

💎 Zinc

3.5 mg

This is heme iron: the body absorbs 15–35% of it, against 2–10% from spinach or dal. One serving does more for haemoglobin than a week of greens.



Rohu Fish Curry

ruhi · labeo rohita

1 piece in gravy (150 g)

200
KCAL

PROTEIN
22g

CARBS
3g

FAT
11g

FIBRE
0.3g

⚡ Vitamin B12

1.5 µg

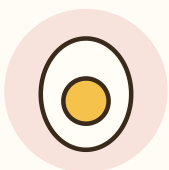
☀️ Vitamin D

2 µg

🍷 Selenium

28 µg

One of the very few foods on an Indian plate that contains vitamin D at all – the nutrient nearly 70% of urban Indians run short of.



Egg, boiled

hen egg, whole

1 large (50 g)

78
KCAL

PROTEIN
6.5g

CARBS
0.6g

FAT
5.3g

FIBRE
0g

⚡ Vitamin B12

0.6 µg

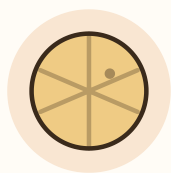
☀️ Vitamin D

1.1 µg

🧠 Choline

147 mg

Every gram of the vitamin D, B12 and choline sits in the yolk. Eating only the white keeps the protein and throws away the micronutrients.



Aloo Paratha

stuffed flatbread, with ghee

1 large (120 g, 2 tsp ghee)

320
KCAL

PROTEIN
6.5g

CARBS
42g

FAT
14g

FIBRE
4g

🌿 Magnesium

55 mg

🩸 Iron

2.0 mg

⚡ Potassium

300 mg

A whole breakfast in one piece. Served with curd it is balanced; served with butter, pickle and sweet chai it is close to half a day's calories.



Samosa

fried maida pastry

1 piece (60 g)

200
KCAL

PROTEIN
3.5g

CARBS
24g

FAT
10g

FIBRE
2g

▲ Sodium

300 mg

⚡ Potassium

210 mg

🩸 Iron

0.8 mg

Refined flour, deep fried, repeatedly reheated oil. Two samosas and a sweet chai is a 500 kcal snack with almost no micronutrient return.



Gajar ka Halwa

carrot pudding

1 small bowl (100 g)

250
KCAL

PROTEIN
4g

CARBS
30g

FAT
12g

FIBRE
2.5g

🟡 Vitamin A

400 µg RAE

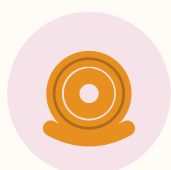
■ Calcium

110 mg

⚡ Potassium

230 mg

The carrot genuinely delivers vitamin A and the khoya delivers calcium – but so does the sugar deliver 6 teaspoons. The best-argued sweet in this book.



Jalebi

syrup-soaked spiral

2 pieces (50 g)

190
KCAL

PROTEIN
1g

CARBS
32g

FAT
7g

FIBRE
0.2g

▲ Sodium

25 mg

■ Calcium

15 mg

🩸 Iron

0.4 mg

Sugar, refined flour and fried fat, with essentially no protein or micronutrient content. The clearest example in this book of calories without nutrition.



Masala Chai

with milk and 1.5 tsp sugar

1 cup (150 ml)

90
KCAL

PROTEIN
2g

CARBS
12g

FAT
3g

FIBRE
0g

■ Calcium

80 mg

⚡ Potassium

110 mg

⚡ Riboflavin

0.1 mg

Tea tannins can cut iron absorption from a meal by up to half. Keep chai an hour away from your dal, saag or rajma – not with them.

QUICK REFERENCE

North India — twenty more

Everyday dishes from this region in short form. Same serving logic as the data cards: one katori is 150 g of cooked food, one glass 200 ml, and any cooking fat named in the note is already counted in the calories.

FOOD	SERVING	KCAL	PROT	CARB	FAT	FIBRE	NOTE
Missi Roti	1 piece, 50 g flour	175	6	28	4	4.4	Atta + besan; more protein
Lachha Paratha	1 piece, 90 g	300	6	40	13	2.4	Layered with ghee
Bhatura	1 piece, 80 g	300	6.5	42	12	1.6	Fermented maida, fried
Jeera Rice	1 katori, 150 g	240	4.2	43	6	0.8	Rice plus 1 tsp ghee
Dal Makhani	1 katori, 150 g	285	9	24	17	6	Urad + cream; fat-heavy
Chole	1 katori, 150 g	225	9	30	8	8.5	Chickpea; high fibre
Kadhi Pakora	1 katori, 150 g	195	6	16	12	2	Besan + curd + fried pakora
Shahi Paneer	1 katori, 150 g	340	12	14	27	1.4	Cream and cashew gravy
Malai Kofta	2 kofta + gravy, 180 g	395	10	24	29	2.2	Fried kofta in cream
Bhindi Masala	1 katori, 150 g	145	3	12	10	4.5	Okra; soluble fibre
Matar Paneer	1 katori, 150 g	265	12	16	18	3.6	Protein-dense vegetarian
Rajma Chawal	1 plate, 300 g	420	13	74	8	9	Complete protein plate
Butter Chicken	1 katori, 150 g	330	22	10	23	1	Cream and butter gravy
Seekh Kebab	2 pieces, 100 g	240	20	5	16	0.6	Minced mutton, grilled
Amritsari Fish	4 pieces, 100 g	245	19	12	14	0.5	Besan batter, fried
Aloo Tikki Chaat	1 plate, 180 g	310	6	42	13	4	Curd and chutney topped
Golgappa (6)	6 pieces, 90 g	175	3	26	6.5	1.6	Fried shells; sodium high
Kulfi	1 piece, 80 g	210	5	22	11	0.3	Reduced milk; calcium
Gulab Jamun	2 pieces, 80 g	300	4	44	12	0.2	Fried khoya, syrup-soaked
Thandai	1 glass, 200 ml	230	7	26	11	1.2	Milk with nuts and seeds

Grams of protein, carbohydrate, fat and dietary fibre per serving. Values are rounded and assume home-style preparation; restaurant versions typically carry 20–40% more fat.



REGION TWO

South India

The most fermented cuisine in India, and the most nutritionally interesting for it — idli, dosa and overnight rice give up their iron and B vitamins far more readily than unfermented food. Coconut is the swing factor: it decides whether a light dish stays light.



Grains & Staples

Matta Rice, Ragi Mudde, Idiyappam, Lemon Rice

Vegetables

Avial, Cabbage Thoran, Drumstick, Vazhakkai Poriyal

Dairy

Curd Rice, Neer More, Cow Milk, Filter Coffee

Snacks

Medu Vada, Murukku, Banana Chips, Masala Vadai

Dals & Legumes

Sambar, Rasam, Kootu, Sundal

Fermented Foods

Idli, Plain Dosa, Onion Uttapam, Appam

Non-Veg

Chettinad Chicken, Meen Kuzhambu, Prawn Thokku, Crab Curry

Sweets & Beverages

Paal Payasam, Mysore Pak, Kesari Bath, Tender Coconut Water





Matta Rice

Kerala red parboiled rice

1 katori cooked (150 g)

190
KCAL

PROTEIN
4.2g

CARBS
41g

FAT
0.6g

FIBRE
2.4g

Magnesium

42 mg

Iron

1.1 mg

Thiamin

0.12 mg

Parboiling drives B vitamins from the bran into the grain before polishing, so red rice keeps four times the thiamin and four times the fibre of white rice.



Ragi Mudde

finger millet ball · ragi sangati

1 ball (120 g cooked)

145
KCAL

PROTEIN
3.4g

CARBS
31g

FAT
0.6g

FIBRE
3.6g

Calcium

130 mg

Iron

1.4 mg

Magnesium

48 mg

The highest-calcium cereal in India — one mudde carries more calcium than half a glass of milk, which is why it anchors the diet where dairy is scarce.



Idiyappam

string hoppers · nool puttu

2 pieces (100 g)

160
KCAL

PROTEIN
3g

CARBS
35g

FAT
0.5g

FIBRE
1.2g

Magnesium

20 mg

Iron

0.5 mg

Potassium

40 mg

Steamed, not fried, and eaten with coconut milk or stew. On its own it is close to pure starch — the protein has to come from what you put beside it.



Lemon Rice

chitranna · elumichai sadam

1 katori (150 g)

245
KCAL

PROTEIN
4g

CARBS
42g

FAT
7g

FIBRE
1.4g

Vitamin C

6 mg

Manganese

0.4 mg

Sodium

320 mg

The lemon is not only flavour — its vitamin C helps you absorb the iron from the dal or greens served with it. Add it after the pan is off the heat.



Ven Pongal

khara pongal · rice-moong

1 katori (150 g)

230
KCAL

PROTEIN
6.5g

CARBS
33g

FAT
8g

FIBRE
2g

Magnesium

38 mg

Folate

60 µg

Zinc

1.0 mg

Rice plus moong dal in one pot is a complete protein — the ghee and pepper are what turn a balanced dish into a heavy one.



Sambar

toor dal with vegetables

1 katori (150 g)

125
KCAL

PROTEIN
5.5g

CARBS
16g

FAT
4.5g

FIBRE
4g

Folate

80 µg

Vitamin A

120 µg RAE

Iron

1.3 mg

The most nutritionally efficient thing on a South Indian plate: dal protein, vegetable fibre, tamarind vitamin C and a tempering that aids absorption, all at once.



Rasam

chaaru · saaru

1 katori (150 g)

55
KCAL

PROTEIN
2g

CARBS
7g

FAT
2.2g

FIBRE
1.2g

Vitamin C

8 mg

Potassium

180 mg

Iron

0.8 mg

Almost no calories, and the tamarind, tomato and pepper in it genuinely help the body pull iron out of the rice and dal eaten alongside.



Kootu

dal with gourd or greens

1 katori (150 g)

140
KCAL

PROTEIN
6g

CARBS
16g

FAT
6g

FIBRE
4.2g

Calcium

90 mg

Folate

70 µg

Magnesium

44 mg

Coconut supplies the fat that carries the vegetable's fat-soluble vitamins – the reason a kootu delivers more usable vitamin A than the same vegetable boiled plain.



Sundal

steamed chickpea, coconut-tossed

1 small bowl (100 g)

185
KCAL

PROTEIN
8.5g

CARBS
27g

FAT
4.5g

FIBRE
7.5g

Iron

2.8 mg

Folate

170 µg

Zinc

1.5 mg

The best snack in this book by a distance – steamed, high in protein and fibre, and the only festival food here that leaves you better off than before you ate it.



Kadala Curry

black chickpea, Kerala style

1 katori (150 g)

210
KCAL

PROTEIN
9g

CARBS
26g

FAT
8g

FIBRE
8g

Iron

3.4 mg

Folate

190 µg

Magnesium

58 mg

Eaten with puttu at breakfast this is a genuinely iron-dense start to the day – keep the coffee an hour away and you keep most of that iron.



Avial

mixed vegetables in coconut-curd

1 katori (150 g)

165
KCAL

PROTEIN
3.5g

CARBS
13g

FAT
11g

FIBRE
4.5g

Vitamin A **240 µg RAE**

Vitamin C **22 mg**

Potassium **380 mg**

Seven vegetables in one katori, which is exactly how dietary variety is supposed to work. The coconut takes it to 11 g of fat – mostly saturated.



Cabbage Thoran

cabbage with grated coconut

1 katori (150 g)

110
KCAL

PROTEIN
2.6g

CARBS
9g

FAT
7g

FIBRE
3.4g

Vitamin C **32 mg**

Vitamin K **70 µg**

Folate **48 µg**

A quick stir-fry keeps the vitamin C that a long boil destroys. Thoran is the technique doing the nutritional work, not the vegetable.



Drumstick

murungakkai · moringa pod

2 pods in curry (80 g)

45
KCAL

PROTEIN
2.2g

CARBS
6g

FAT
0.6g

FIBRE
3.2g

Vitamin C **110 mg**

Calcium **24 mg**

Potassium **260 mg**

More vitamin C per pod than an orange. That matters most for what it does to the iron in the sambar it is cooked in.



Vazhakkai Poriyal

raw banana stir-fry

1 katori (150 g)

150
KCAL

PROTEIN
2g

CARBS
24g

FAT
6g

FIBRE
4g

Potassium **420 mg**

Vitamin B6 **0.3 mg**

Magnesium **36 mg**

Raw banana is largely resistant starch – it feeds gut bacteria rather than spiking blood sugar, which is why it suits diabetic plates better than potato.



Vazhaithandu

banana stem

1 katori (150 g)

60
KCAL

PROTEIN
1.5g

CARBS
9g

FAT
1.8g

FIBRE
3g

Potassium **280 mg**

Iron **0.9 mg**

Magnesium **30 mg**

Traditionally eaten to prevent kidney stones, and the reasoning holds: it is mostly water and potassium with very little oxalate of its own.



Idli

steamed rice-urad cake

2 pieces (100 g)

120
KCAL

PROTEIN
4g

CARBS
24g

FAT
0.6g

FIBRE
1g

Folate

30 µg

Iron

0.9 mg

Vitamin B12

0.1 µg

Fermentation breaks down phytate and generates B vitamins, so an idli gives up its iron and zinc far more readily than the same rice and dal cooked unfermented.



Plain Dosa

rice-urad crepe

1 medium (80 g, 1 tsp oil)

165
KCAL

PROTEIN
3.6g

CARBS
26g

FAT
5g

FIBRE
1.2g

Folate

26 µg

Iron

0.8 mg

Magnesium

22 mg

The batter is identical to idli; the oil on the tawa is the entire difference. A masala dosa with potato and ghee lands closer to 380 kcal.



Onion Uttapam

thick topped pancake

1 piece (120 g)

210
KCAL

PROTEIN
5g

CARBS
33g

FAT
6.5g

FIBRE
2.4g

Folate

40 µg

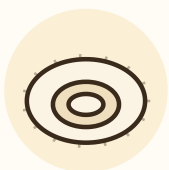
Vitamin C

6 mg

Iron

1.1 mg

The vegetable topping is not decoration – it is what lifts a fermented starch into a breakfast with fibre and vitamin C in it.



Appam

fermented rice-coconut hopper

2 pieces (110 g)

185
KCAL

PROTEIN
3.2g

CARBS
34g

FAT
4g

FIBRE
1.4g

Magnesium

24 mg

Potassium

90 mg

Iron

0.7 mg

Toddy or yeast does the fermenting here. Light on its own – the stew it is served with usually carries twice its calories.



Pazhaya Sadam

fermented overnight rice

1 katori (200 g)

155
KCAL

PROTEIN
3.6g

CARBS
32g

FAT
0.8g

FIBRE
1.4g

Vitamin B12

0.2 µg

Iron

1.6 mg

Potassium

220 mg

Overnight fermentation multiplies the available iron and B vitamins in cooked rice and adds live cultures. The most under-rated food in this book.



Curd Rice

thayir sadam · mosaranna

1 katori (200 g)

210
KCAL

PROTEIN
6.5g

CARBS
34g

FAT
5g

FIBRE
0.8g

■ Calcium

160 mg

⚡ Vitamin B12

0.4 µg

⚡ Riboflavin

0.2 mg

Cooling, probiotic and easy on an inflamed gut – the traditional last course exists for a reason. Its calcium does blunt iron uptake, so it belongs at the end, not the start.



Neer More

spiced thin buttermilk

1 glass (200 ml)

45
KCAL

PROTEIN
2.4g

CARBS
4g

FAT
2g

FIBRE
0.2g

■ Calcium

90 mg

⚡ Potassium

180 mg

▲ Sodium

200 mg

A quarter of the calories of sweet lassi with the same probiotics and salts – the better answer to an Indian summer.



Cow Milk

toned, boiled

1 glass (200 ml)

120
KCAL

PROTEIN
6.4g

CARBS
9.6g

FAT
6g

FIBRE
0g

■ Calcium

240 mg

⚡ Vitamin B12

0.9 µg

⚡ Riboflavin

0.3 mg

Two-thirds the calories of buffalo milk for nearly the same protein – the sensible default for anyone drinking milk daily.



Filter Coffee

degree kaapi, with sugar

1 tumbler (150 ml)

95
KCAL

PROTEIN
3g

CARBS
12g

FAT
3.6g

FIBRE
0g

■ Calcium

110 mg

⚡ Potassium

140 mg

⚡ Riboflavin

0.15 mg

Coffee polyphenols cut non-heme iron absorption sharply – a tumbler with breakfast can undo much of the iron in the idli it washes down.



Thick Curd

thayir · mosaru

1 katori (150 g)

90
KCAL

PROTEIN
5g

CARBS
7g

FAT
4.8g

FIBRE
0g

■ Calcium

180 mg

⚡ Vitamin B12

0.5 µg

🏠 Phosphorus

140 mg

Set at home from toned milk it is the cheapest probiotic available in India, and it survives the climate better than milk does.



Chettinad Chicken

pepper-spiced chicken curry

1 katori (150 g)

250
KCAL

PROTEIN
25g

CARBS
6g

FAT
13.5g

FIBRE
1g

⚡ Vitamin B12

0.6 µg

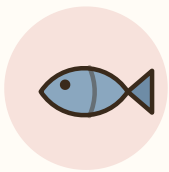
💎 Zinc

2.2 mg

🍷 Selenium

22 µg

Black pepper's piperine measurably improves how much of several nutrients you absorb – the spice blend here does more than heat.



Meen Kuzhambu

tamarind fish curry

1 katori (150 g)

190
KCAL

PROTEIN
21g

CARBS
6g

FAT
9g

FIBRE
1g

☀️ Vitamin D

2.5 µg

⚡ Vitamin B12

1.8 µg

🍷 Selenium

30 µg

Tamarind's acidity plus fish protein is one of the better iron-absorption combinations on any Indian table.



Prawn Thokku

eral · chemmeen roast

1 katori (120 g)

185
KCAL

PROTEIN
20g

CARBS
5g

FAT
9.5g

FIBRE
0.6g

⚡ Vitamin B12

1.2 µg

🍷 Selenium

38 µg

💎 Zinc

1.6 mg

High in cholesterol but low in saturated fat – for most people the second number matters more than the first.



Crab Curry

nandu kuzhambu

1 katori (150 g)

175
KCAL

PROTEIN
18g

CARBS
6g

FAT
8.5g

FIBRE
1g

💎 Zinc

4.2 mg

⚡ Vitamin B12

6.0 µg

🍷 Copper

0.7 mg

One of the densest sources of zinc and B12 in Indian cooking – a single serving covers an adult's daily need for both several times over.



Mutton Sukka

dry-roasted goat with coconut

1 katori (130 g)

285
KCAL

PROTEIN
23g

CARBS
5g

FAT
19g

FIBRE
1.2g

🩸 Iron

3.0 mg

⚡ Vitamin B12

2.0 µg

💎 Zinc

3.8 mg

Dry-roasting concentrates everything, including the fat from the coconut. Heme iron and zinc here are the payoff for the calories.



Medu Vada

urad dal doughnut

1 piece (50 g)

160
KCAL

PROTEIN
4g

CARBS
15g

FAT
9.5g

FIBRE
1.6g

Iron

1.2 mg

Folate

35 µg

Magnesium

28 mg

Urad dal gives it real protein, and deep frying gives it nine grams of fat. Better than most fried snacks, worse than anything steamed.



Murukku

chakli · rice-urad spiral

3 pieces (40 g)

200
KCAL

PROTEIN
3.2g

CARBS
22g

FAT
11g

FIBRE
1.2g

Sodium

260 mg

Iron

0.9 mg

Magnesium

20 mg

Half its calories are frying oil, and oil reused across batches carries the compounds you least want. Freshly made matters more than the recipe.



Banana Chips

nendran, coconut-oil fried

30 g (small handful)

170
KCAL

PROTEIN
0.6g

CARBS
18g

FAT
10.5g

FIBRE
1.2g

Potassium

160 mg

Sodium

90 mg

Magnesium

12 mg

Coconut oil frying makes these more saturated than most chips. The fruit they started as is not doing much for you by this point.



Masala Vadai

chana dal fritter

2 pieces (60 g)

190
KCAL

PROTEIN
6.5g

CARBS
18g

FAT
10g

FIBRE
3g

Iron

1.8 mg

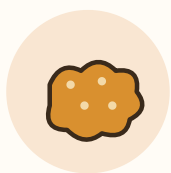
Folate

60 µg

Zinc

1.0 mg

The most protein-dense fried snack here – chana dal keeps 6.5 g of protein and 3 g of fibre intact through the fryer.



Bajji

onion or plantain fritter

2 pieces (70 g)

205
KCAL

PROTEIN
4g

CARBS
22g

FAT
11.5g

FIBRE
2.2g

Iron

1.2 mg

Sodium

280 mg

Folate

38 µg

Besan batter carries decent protein into the pan; what comes out is defined by how long it sat in the oil.



Paal Payasam

rice and milk pudding

1 small bowl (120 g)

225
KCAL

PROTEIN
5.5g

CARBS
36g

FAT
6.5g

FIBRE
0.4g

■ Calcium

180 mg

⚡ Vitamin B12

0.5 µg

⚡ Riboflavin

0.2 mg

Milk-based sweets at least carry calcium and B12 alongside the sugar – a better trade than a purely fried one.



Mysore Pak

besan, ghee and sugar

1 piece (40 g)

215
KCAL

PROTEIN
2.5g

CARBS
24g

FAT
12.5g

FIBRE
0.8g

● Iron

0.7 mg

◆ Magnesium

20 mg

◀ Folate

22 µg

Ghee is close to a third of its weight. There is no version of this that is a health food, and it was never pretending to be.



Kesari Bath

rava sheera

1 small bowl (100 g)

280
KCAL

PROTEIN
4g

CARBS
42g

FAT
11g

FIBRE
1g

● Iron

1.0 mg

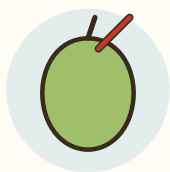
◆ Magnesium

18 mg

■ Calcium

30 mg

Semolina, sugar and ghee in near-equal measure. Served as breakfast in many homes, which is how a dessert quietly becomes a daily meal.



Tender Coconut Water

elaneer · bondam

1 whole nut (250 ml)

45
KCAL

PROTEIN
0.5g

CARBS
10g

FAT
0.2g

FIBRE
0g

⚡ Potassium

620 mg

▲ Sodium

60 mg

◆ Magnesium

16 mg

A genuine oral rehydration drink – the potassium-to-sodium balance is close to what the body loses in sweat, and there is no added sugar in it.



Sugarcane Juice

karumbu juice

1 glass (200 ml)

150
KCAL

PROTEIN
0.4g

CARBS
37g

FAT
0.2g

FIBRE
0.4g

● Iron

1.2 mg

■ Calcium

20 mg

⚡ Potassium

150 mg

Unrefined, so it keeps traces of iron and potassium cane sugar loses – but it is still roughly nine teaspoons of sugar in a glass.

QUICK REFERENCE

South India — twenty more

Everyday dishes from this region in short form. Same serving logic as the data cards: one katori is 150 g of cooked food, one glass 200 ml, and any cooking fat named in the note is already counted in the calories.

FOOD	SERVING	KCAL	PROT	CARB	FAT	FIBRE	NOTE
Puttu (rice-coconut)	1 cylinder, 120 g	195	3.4	38	3.5	2.2	Steamed; coconut adds the fat
Upma	1 katori, 150 g	230	5	33	8.5	2	Rava; low fibre unless veg-loaded
Bisi Bele Bath	1 katori, 180 g	290	8.5	42	9.5	4	Rice + dal + veg in one
Rava Dosa	1 piece, 90 g	205	3.5	27	9	1	More oil than a plain dosa
Set Dosa	2 pieces, 110 g	195	4.5	33	4.5	1.6	Fermented; softer, less oil
Neer Dosa	3 pieces, 120 g	165	2.8	34	1.6	0.8	Unfermented rice batter
Akki Roti	1 piece, 90 g	200	3.4	34	5.5	1.8	Rice flour; gluten-free
Thattu Idli	3 pieces, 120 g	145	4.8	29	0.7	1.2	Same batter, thinner
Coconut Chutney	2 tbsp, 30 g	70	1	3	6	1.4	Almost all coconut fat
Tomato Chutney	2 tbsp, 30 g	35	0.6	4	2	0.8	Lycopene; low calorie
Molagapodi with oil	1 tbsp, 15 g	90	2.8	6	6	1.6	Dal-based; salt is high
Paruppu Usili	1 katori, 120 g	195	9	18	9	6	Highest-protein sabzi here
Beans Poriyal	1 katori, 150 g	105	3	10	6	4	Vitamin K and fibre
Keerai Masiyal	1 katori, 150 g	75	4.2	7	3.5	3.2	Amaranth greens; oxalate-bound iron
Pepper Rasam	1 katori, 150 g	50	1.8	6	2	1	Piperine aids absorption
Mor Kuzhambu	1 katori, 150 g	145	5	12	8.5	2	Curd + coconut base
Puliyodarai	1 katori, 150 g	265	4.2	44	8	2	Tamarind rice; oil-heavy
Chicken 65	5 pieces, 100 g	235	19	12	12.5	0.6	Battered and deep fried
Fish Fry (seer)	1 slice, 100 g	210	22	6	11	0.3	Vitamin D and B12
Jangiri	1 piece, 40 g	165	1.6	27	6	0.4	Urad flour; syrup-soaked

Grams of protein, carbohydrate, fat and dietary fibre per serving. Values are rounded and assume home-style preparation; restaurant versions typically carry 20–40% more fat.



REGION THREE

East India

Rice and river fish, with mustard oil doing most of the cooking. The fish brings vitamin D, B12 and omega-3 that vegetarian regions struggle to match; the sweets, almost all milk-based, bring calcium alongside the sugar.



Grains & Staples

Bhaat, Panta Bhaat, Chire, Muri

Vegetables

Shukto, Aloo Posto, Begun Bhaja, Lau Ghonto

Fermented Foods & Snacks

Jhal Muri, Singara, Beguni, Aloo Chop

Dals & Legumes

Cholar Dal, Musur Dal, Ghugni, Bori

Non-Veg & River Fish

Machher Jhol, Ilish Bhapa, Chingri Malai Curry, Kosha Mangsho

Sweets & Beverages

Rasgulla, Sandesh, Mishti Doi, Payesh





Bhaat

steamed white rice

1 katori cooked (150 g)

195
KCAL

PROTEIN
4g

CARBS
43g

FAT
0.4g

FIBRE
0.6g

🌿 Magnesium

18 mg

⚡ Thiamin

0.05 mg

⚡ Potassium

55 mg

Eastern India eats more rice per head than anywhere else in the country, which makes what sits beside it – dal, fish, greens – the whole nutritional argument.



Panta Bhaat

water-soaked fermented rice

1 katori (200 g)

150
KCAL

PROTEIN
3.6g

CARBS
31g

FAT
0.7g

FIBRE
1.2g

🩸 Iron

2.0 mg

⚡ Vitamin B12

0.2 µg

⚡ Potassium

240 mg

Overnight soaking multiplies the iron the body can actually take up and adds live bacteria – a poor man's breakfast that outperforms most expensive ones.



Chire

flattened rice · chira

1 katori dry (50 g)

175
KCAL

PROTEIN
3.4g

CARBS
38g

FAT
0.6g

FIBRE
1.4g

🩸 Iron

10.0 mg

🌿 Magnesium

24 mg

⚡ Potassium

70 mg

Unusually high in iron because of the iron rollers used to flatten it. Soak it in curd with jaggery and you have a breakfast with real mineral content.



Muri

puffed rice · murmura

1 large bowl (30 g)

115
KCAL

PROTEIN
2g

CARBS
26g

FAT
0.3g

FIBRE
0.6g

🩸 Iron

1.0 mg

▲ Sodium

35 mg

🌿 Magnesium

10 mg

Air and starch. Filling for very few calories, which makes it useful – until it arrives as jhal muri with oil, sev and chanachur.



Pitha

steamed rice cake, coconut-jaggery

1 piece (70 g)

175
KCAL

PROTEIN
2.6g

CARBS
30g

FAT
5g

FIBRE
1.6g

🩸 Iron

1.2 mg

■ Calcium

30 mg

🌿 Magnesium

20 mg

Jaggery keeps the iron and minerals that refining strips from white sugar – a real difference, though not enough to call a sweet nutritious.



Cholar Dal

chana dal with coconut

1 katori (150 g)

195
KCAL

PROTEIN
8.5g

CARBS
28g

FAT
5.5g

FIBRE
6g

Folate

115 µg

Iron

1.9 mg

Magnesium

58 mg

Low glycaemic and high fibre even with the sugar and ghee the Bengali version carries – the dal underneath is doing the heavy lifting.



Musur Dal

red lentil · masoor

1 katori (150 g)

115
KCAL

PROTEIN
7.5g

CARBS
18g

FAT
0.8g

FIBRE
3.8g

Folate

105 µg

Iron

1.6 mg

Potassium

290 mg

The fastest-cooking dal in India and among the highest in folate – which matters most in the first weeks of a pregnancy, often before anyone knows.



Ghugni

dried yellow peas curry

1 katori (150 g)

180
KCAL

PROTEIN
9.5g

CARBS
27g

FAT
3.5g

FIBRE
7g

Iron

2.6 mg

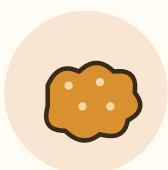
Folate

150 µg

Zinc

1.7 mg

Street food with the nutrition profile of a proper meal – nearly 10 g of protein and 7 g of fibre for the price of a samosa.



Bori

sun-dried lentil dumplings

6 pieces (25 g dry)

90
KCAL

PROTEIN
5.5g

CARBS
13g

FAT
1.4g

FIBRE
3g

Iron

1.4 mg

Folate

45 µg

Magnesium

36 mg

Concentrated dal, sun-dried for months without refrigeration. Fried before use, which is where the fat arrives.



Kalai Dal

urad dal, Bengali style

1 katori (150 g)

140
KCAL

PROTEIN
8g

CARBS
20g

FAT
2.6g

FIBRE
4.5g

Iron

2.0 mg

Calcium

60 mg

Magnesium

50 mg

Urad carries more calcium than any other common dal – useful on a plate that leans away from dairy.



Shukto

mixed vegetables, bitter

1 katori (150 g)

140
KCAL

PROTEIN
3.5g

CARBS
15g

FAT
7.5g

FIBRE
4.5g

Vitamin A

210 µg RAE

Potassium

360 mg

Folate

50 µg

The bitter gourd in it does modestly lower post-meal blood sugar. Eaten first in the Bengali sequence, which is exactly when that helps most.



Aloo Posto

potato with poppy seed paste

1 katori (150 g)

215
KCAL

PROTEIN
4.5g

CARBS
24g

FAT
11g

FIBRE
3g

Calcium

160 mg

Magnesium

60 mg

Iron

2.2 mg

Poppy seeds are quietly one of the best plant calcium sources in Indian cooking – a tablespoon carries more than a third of a glass of milk.



Begun Bhaja

fried aubergine slices

3 slices (100 g)

165
KCAL

PROTEIN
1.6g

CARBS
9g

FAT
14g

FIBRE
3g

Potassium

240 mg

Folate

25 µg

Manganese

0.25 mg

Aubergine soaks up oil like a sponge – the slices absorb three to four times what the same weight of potato would.



Lau Ghonto

bottle gourd mash

1 katori (150 g)

95
KCAL

PROTEIN
2g

CARBS
9g

FAT
5.5g

FIBRE
2.6g

Potassium

220 mg

Vitamin C

10 mg

Magnesium

24 mg

Bottle gourd is 95% water. Whatever calories a lau dish carries came out of the oil bottle, not the vegetable.



Palong Shaak

spinach, lightly cooked

1 katori (150 g)

70
KCAL

PROTEIN
4g

CARBS
6g

FAT
3.5g

FIBRE
3g

Iron

2.6 mg

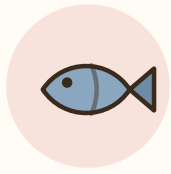
Vitamin A

580 µg RAE

Folate

95 µg

Cook it with a squeeze of lime rather than with paneer – vitamin C raises the iron you absorb, calcium lowers it.



Machher Jhol

rohu in light curry

1 piece + gravy (150 g)

195
KCAL

PROTEIN
22g

CARBS
4g

FAT
10g

FIBRE
0.4g

⚡ Vitamin B12

1.5 µg

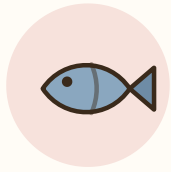
☀ Vitamin D

2.0 µg

🍷 Selenium

28 µg

A light jhol keeps the fish's vitamin D and B12 intact where deep frying and long reheating degrade them.



Ilish Bhapa

steamed hilsa in mustard

1 piece (120 g)

310
KCAL

PROTEIN
21g

CARBS
3g

FAT
24g

FIBRE
0.5g

🔄 Omega-3

2.4 g

☀ Vitamin D

4.5 µg

⚡ Vitamin B12

2.6 µg

One of the richest omega-3 sources on any Indian plate. Steaming in mustard keeps those fragile fats from oxidising the way frying does.



Chingri Malai Curry

prawn in coconut milk

1 katori (150 g)

265
KCAL

PROTEIN
19g

CARBS
7g

FAT
18g

FIBRE
0.8g

⚡ Vitamin B12

1.3 µg

🍷 Selenium

36 µg

🍷 Zinc

1.8 mg

The prawns are lean; the coconut milk is not. Two-thirds of these calories arrive with the gravy.



Kosha Mangsho

slow-cooked mutton

1 katori (150 g)

330
KCAL

PROTEIN
23g

CARBS
5g

FAT
24g

FIBRE
0.6g

🩸 Iron

3.0 mg

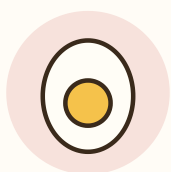
⚡ Vitamin B12

2.2 µg

🍷 Zinc

4.0 mg

Long slow cooking in mustard oil – excellent iron and zinc, and the highest saturated fat of any main dish in this book.



Dim Curry

egg in potato gravy

1 egg + gravy (160 g)

210
KCAL

PROTEIN
8.5g

CARBS
12g

FAT
14g

FIBRE
1.4g

⚡ Vitamin B12

0.6 µg

☀ Vitamin D

1.1 µg

🔗 Choline

150 mg

The egg brings the micronutrients, the gravy brings the calories. Halving the oil changes this dish more than changing anything else in it.



Jhal Muri

spiced puffed rice

1 paper cone (60 g)

185
KCAL

PROTEIN
3.6g

CARBS
28g

FAT
7g

FIBRE
2g

▲ Sodium

420 mg



Iron

1.4 mg



Potassium

160 mg

Mustard oil, peanuts and raw onion lift it above plain fried snacks – the salt, though, is close to a fifth of a day's limit in one cone.



Singara

Bengali samosa

1 piece (65 g)

215
KCAL

PROTEIN
3.8g

CARBS
25g

FAT
11g

FIBRE
2.2g

▲ Sodium

320 mg



Potassium

220 mg



Iron

0.9 mg

Peanuts and cauliflower in the filling make it marginally better than its northern cousin. The maida shell and the fryer still decide the numbers.



Beguni

aubergine in besan batter

2 pieces (70 g)

200
KCAL

PROTEIN
4.2g

CARBS
19g

FAT
12g

FIBRE
2.6g

● Iron

1.3 mg



Folate

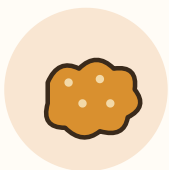
40 µg



Magnesium

30 mg

Besan gives it protein the batter of a chip never has – which is the only reason this ranks above a crisp.



Aloo Chop

potato cutlet, fried

1 piece (80 g)

225
KCAL

PROTEIN
3.4g

CARBS
27g

FAT
12g

FIBRE
2.4g

⚡ Potassium

330 mg



Sodium

300 mg



Vitamin C

8 mg

A boiled potato is 80 kcal. The same potato mashed, battered and fried is nearly three times that – the transformation is entirely fat.



Aam Kasundi

fermented mustard relish

1 tbsp (15 g)

25
KCAL

PROTEIN
0.8g

CARBS
2g

FAT
1.4g

FIBRE
0.4g

▲ Sodium

290 mg



Selenium

5 µg



Magnesium

8 mg

Fermented mustard, so it carries live cultures and glucosinolates – but a spoon also carries a tenth of the day's sodium.



Rasgulla

chhena in syrup

2 pieces (80 g)

185
KCAL

PROTEIN
4g

CARBS
34g

FAT
3.5g

FIBRE
0g

■ Calcium

120 mg

⚡ Vitamin B12

0.3 µg

⬢ Phosphorus

90 mg

Chhena is milk protein, so this is one of the few sweets with real protein in it. The syrup is still the majority of the calories.



Sandesh

chhena sweet, lightly sugared

2 pieces (60 g)

195
KCAL

PROTEIN
7g

CARBS
22g

FAT
8.5g

FIBRE
0g

■ Calcium

210 mg

⚡ Vitamin B12

0.4 µg

⬢ Phosphorus

150 mg

Less syrup than a rasgulla and more protein per bite – the most defensible Bengali sweet on nutritional grounds.



Mishti Doi

sweetened baked curd

1 small pot (100 g)

175
KCAL

PROTEIN
4.5g

CARBS
27g

FAT
5.5g

FIBRE
0g

■ Calcium

160 mg

⚡ Vitamin B12

0.4 µg

⚡ Riboflavin

0.2 mg

Probiotics and calcium, plus around five teaspoons of sugar. Plain curd with a little jaggery gets you most of the good half.



Payesh

rice kheer with jaggery

1 small bowl (120 g)

215
KCAL

PROTEIN
5g

CARBS
34g

FAT
6.5g

FIBRE
0.5g

■ Calcium

170 mg

🔴 Iron

1.0 mg

⚡ Vitamin B12

0.4 µg

Date-palm jaggery gives it iron and a trace of minerals white sugar cannot. It remains a dessert, only a better-argued one.



Cha

Bengali milk tea with sugar

1 cup (150 ml)

85
KCAL

PROTEIN
2g

CARBS
11g

FAT
3g

FIBRE
0g

■ Calcium

75 mg

⚡ Potassium

105 mg

⚡ Riboflavin

0.1 mg

Four to six cups a day is common here, and each one taken with a meal cuts the iron absorbed from that meal. Timing is the whole fix.

QUICK REFERENCE

East India — twenty more

Everyday dishes from this region in short form. Same serving logic as the data cards: one katori is 150 g of cooked food, one glass 200 ml, and any cooking fat named in the note is already counted in the calories.

FOOD	SERVING	KCAL	PROT	CARB	FAT	FIBRE	NOTE
Luchi	2 pieces, 70 g	230	4	28	11	1.2	Maida, deep fried
Radha Ballabhi	1 piece, 60 g	215	4.5	24	11	2	Dal-stuffed, fried
Khichuri	1 katori, 180 g	245	8	38	6.5	3.5	Rice + moong; complete protein
Doi Maach	1 piece, 150 g	220	21	6	12	0.4	Curd-based fish curry
Shorshe Ilish	1 piece, 120 g	325	21	4	25	0.6	Mustard + hilsa; omega-3 rich
Chitol Mutha	1 katori, 150 g	250	20	9	15	0.8	Fish dumplings in gravy
Mocha Ghonto	1 katori, 150 g	155	4	16	8	5.5	Banana flower; very high fibre
Echorer Dalna	1 katori, 150 g	175	3.5	18	10	4.5	Raw jackfruit; meat-like texture
Dhokar Dalna	1 katori, 150 g	245	9	24	12.5	5	Chana dal cakes in gravy
Postor Bora	2 pieces, 50 g	175	3.5	8	14	1.6	Poppy seed fritter; calcium
Chanachur	30 g handful	155	4	16	8.5	2	Fried; sodium heavy
Nolen Gur Sandesh	2 pieces, 60 g	200	6.5	24	8	0	Date palm jaggery
Pantua	1 piece, 45 g	190	3	26	8.5	0	Fried khoya, syrup-soaked
Chhanar Jilipi	1 piece, 45 g	185	3.5	25	8	0	Chhena; syrup-soaked
Aam Doi	1 pot, 100 g	150	4	24	4	0.4	Mango + curd
Tok Dal	1 katori, 150 g	110	6.5	17	1.2	3.2	Masoor with raw mango
Kumro Chhechki	1 katori, 150 g	120	2.2	14	6.5	3	Pumpkin; vitamin A
Jhinge Posto	1 katori, 150 g	165	3.4	12	11.5	2.8	Ridge gourd + poppy seed
Muri Ghonto	1 katori, 150 g	235	14	22	10	1.4	Fish head with rice
Gondhoraj Ghol	1 glass, 200 ml	60	2.6	6	2.4	0.2	Buttermilk with lime

Grams of protein, carbohydrate, fat and dietary fibre per serving. Values are rounded and assume home-style preparation; restaurant versions typically carry 20–40% more fat.



REGION FOUR

West India

Millets and sprouts on one side, farsan and mithai on the other. This is the region with both the highest-fibre everyday dishes in the country and the densest fried snacks — often on the same plate.



Grains & Staples

Jowar Bhakri, Methi Thepla, Puran Poli, Kanda Poha

Vegetables

Undhiyu, Bharli Vangi, Sev Tameta, Gawar Sabzi

Non-Veg & Coastal

Malvani Fish Curry, Bombil Fry, Prawn Koliwada, Chicken Kolhapuri

Sweets & Beverages

Ukadiche Modak, Mohanthai, Kaju Katli, Aam Ras

Dals & Legumes

Gujarati Dal, Matki Usal, Kadhi, Dal Dhokli

Dairy

Shrikhand, Chaas, Dahi Vada, Basundi

Snacks & Farsan

Khaman Dhokla, Khandvi, Fafda, Sev





Jowar Bhakri

sorghum flatbread

1 bhakri (50 g flour)

175
KCAL

PROTEIN
5g

CARBS
34g

FAT
1.4g

FIBRE
4.8g

Iron

2.1 mg

Magnesium

70 mg

Zinc

1.2 mg

Gluten-free, slower to raise blood sugar than wheat, and holding four times the fibre of a maida roti – the millet that never left the Deccan plate.



Methi Thepla

fenugreek flatbread

2 pieces (80 g)

235
KCAL

PROTEIN
6g

CARBS
32g

FAT
9g

FIBRE
4.4g

Iron

2.6 mg

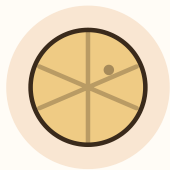
Calcium

110 mg

Vitamin A

150 µg RAE

Fenugreek leaves add iron and calcium to plain atta, and the soluble fibre in them has a measurable effect on post-meal glucose.



Puran Poli

jaggery-dal stuffed bread

1 piece (100 g)

330
KCAL

PROTEIN
7g

CARBS
52g

FAT
10g

FIBRE
3.6g

Iron

2.4 mg

Folate

70 µg

Magnesium

45 mg

Chana dal and jaggery give it protein and iron no other festival sweet here can claim – it is still a third of a day's calories in one piece.



Kanda Poha

flattened rice with onion

1 plate (150 g)

250
KCAL

PROTEIN
4.5g

CARBS
40g

FAT
8g

FIBRE
2.4g

Iron

6.5 mg

Potassium

180 mg

Vitamin C

8 mg

Poha's iron is unusually high, and the lemon squeezed over it at the end is what makes that iron available. Do not skip the wedge.



Gujarati Khichdi

rice and moong dal

1 katori (180 g)

235
KCAL

PROTEIN
7.5g

CARBS
38g

FAT
5.5g

FIBRE
3g

Folate

75 µg

Magnesium

48 mg

Zinc

1.2 mg

Rice and dal in a 3:1 ratio is a complete protein, easy to digest and cheap – the reason it is the default sick-day meal across the country.



Gujarati Dal

toor dal, sweet-sour

1 katori (150 g)

140
KCAL

PROTEIN
6g

CARBS
21g

FAT
3.4g

FIBRE
4.2g

Folate

85 µg

Iron

1.2 mg

Potassium

300 mg

The jaggery adds about two teaspoons of sugar per katori. Worth knowing if dal is your daily dish and your blood sugar is being watched.



Matki Usal

sprouted moth beans

1 katori (150 g)

165
KCAL

PROTEIN
9.5g

CARBS
22g

FAT
4.5g

FIBRE
7.5g

Iron

2.8 mg

Folate

165 µg

Vitamin C

12 mg

Sprouting cuts phytate, raises vitamin C from nothing to something, and roughly doubles the iron your body can actually absorb. The single best trick in this book.



Kadhi

besan and curd

1 katori (150 g)

120
KCAL

PROTEIN
4.5g

CARBS
11g

FAT
6.5g

FIBRE
1.6g

Calcium

130 mg

Vitamin B12

0.3 µg

Folate

30 µg

Besan and curd together make a complete protein at very few calories – the tempering is the only place fat enters.



Dal Dhokli

dal with wheat strips

1 katori (180 g)

265
KCAL

PROTEIN
9.5g

CARBS
38g

FAT
8g

FIBRE
5g

Iron

2.4 mg

Folate

90 µg

Magnesium

62 mg

A one-pot meal that manages grain, dal and fat in sensible proportion – closer to a balanced plate than most single dishes here.



Misal

sprouts in spiced gravy

1 katori (180 g)

240
KCAL

PROTEIN
10g

CARBS
26g

FAT
10.5g

FIBRE
8g

Iron

3.2 mg

Folate

180 µg

Zinc

1.8 mg

Before the farsan and pav arrive, misal is one of the highest-fibre dishes in Indian cooking. After they arrive, it is a 600 kcal plate.



Undhiyu

winter vegetable medley

1 katori (150 g)

225
KCAL

PROTEIN
6g

CARBS
22g

FAT
13g

FIBRE
7g

Vitamin A

260 µg RAE

Folate

95 µg

Potassium

480 mg

Eight or nine vegetables and legumes in one pot – the fibre and micronutrient spread is exceptional. So is the oil it is slow-cooked in.



Bharli Vangi

stuffed baby aubergine

2 pieces (150 g)

205
KCAL

PROTEIN
4.5g

CARBS
15g

FAT
14g

FIBRE
5g

Magnesium

60 mg

Iron

1.8 mg

Potassium

320 mg

The peanut-coconut masala is where the calories live, and also where the magnesium and iron come from. Not all fat on a plate is equal.



Sev Tameta

tomato curry with sev

1 katori (150 g)

195
KCAL

PROTEIN
4g

CARBS
18g

FAT
11.5g

FIBRE
2.6g

Vitamin C

18 mg

Vitamin A

90 µg RAE

Potassium

340 mg

Cooking tomatoes in oil makes their lycopene far more absorbable. The fried sev on top is the part with nothing to recommend it.



Gawar Sabzi

cluster beans

1 katori (150 g)

130
KCAL

PROTEIN
4g

CARBS
14g

FAT
6.5g

FIBRE
6g

Iron

2.4 mg

Calcium

115 mg

Potassium

290 mg

Guar gum comes from this bean, and it behaves the same way on your plate – soluble fibre that slows sugar absorption measurably.



Methi Bhaji

fenugreek greens

1 katori (150 g)

105
KCAL

PROTEIN
4.5g

CARBS
8g

FAT
6g

FIBRE
4g

Iron

3.0 mg

Calcium

195 mg

Vitamin A

420 µg RAE

Among the most calcium-dense greens in India, and the mild bitterness comes from compounds with a real, if modest, glucose-lowering effect.



Shrikhand

hung curd with sugar

1 small bowl (100 g)

245
KCAL

PROTEIN
6g

CARBS
32g

FAT
10g

FIBRE
0.2g

■ Calcium

180 mg

⚡ Vitamin B12

0.4 µg

🏠 Phosphorus

150 mg

Hung curd concentrates the protein and calcium – then roughly six teaspoons of sugar go back in. The base is excellent; the finish is not.



Chaas

spiced thin buttermilk

1 glass (200 ml)

50
KCAL

PROTEIN
2.6g

CARBS
4.5g

FAT
2.2g

FIBRE
0.2g

■ Calcium

95 mg

⚡ Potassium

190 mg

▲ Sodium

210 mg

The standard Gujarati end to a meal, and a sound one – probiotics and electrolytes at a quarter of the calories of lassi.



Dahi Vada

urad dumplings in spiced curd

2 pieces + curd (180 g)

235
KCAL

PROTEIN
7.5g

CARBS
26g

FAT
11g

FIBRE
2.6g

■ Calcium

165 mg

⚡ Vitamin B12

0.4 µg

🌱 Folate

45 µg

The curd is doing the good work and the fryer is doing the damage. Soaking the vadas in hot water first, then curd, squeezes out a good part of the oil.



Basundi

reduced sweetened milk

1 small bowl (100 g)

265
KCAL

PROTEIN
7g

CARBS
30g

FAT
13g

FIBRE
0g

■ Calcium

260 mg

⚡ Vitamin B12

0.7 µg

⚡ Riboflavin

0.3 mg

Milk reduced to a third of its volume concentrates the calcium and the fat together – a quarter of the day's calcium and a fifth of its saturated fat.



Masala Doodh

saffron-cardamom milk

1 glass (200 ml)

210
KCAL

PROTEIN
7g

CARBS
22g

FAT
10g

FIBRE
0.2g

■ Calcium

280 mg

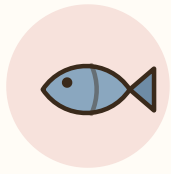
⚡ Vitamin B12

0.8 µg

🌱 Magnesium

40 mg

The nuts add magnesium and vitamin E worth having. The added sugar adds about four teaspoons worth of nothing.



Malvani Fish Curry

surmai in coconut masala

1 piece + gravy (150 g)

245
KCAL

PROTEIN
22g

CARBS
6g

FAT
15g

FIBRE
1.2g



Vitamin D

3.0 µg



Vitamin B12

1.9 µg



Selenium

34 µg

Kingfish is among the better vitamin D sources available to an Indian kitchen – coconut and kokum contribute flavour, not much else.



Bombil Fry

Bombay duck, rava-fried

2 pieces (100 g)

215
KCAL

PROTEIN
19g

CARBS
9g

FAT
11.5g

FIBRE
0.4g



Calcium

120 mg



Vitamin B12

1.4 µg



Phosphorus

190 mg

Eaten with the fine bones, which is where its unusually high calcium comes from – small whole fish beat fillets on minerals every time.



Prawn Koliwada

batter-fried prawns

6 pieces (100 g)

230
KCAL

PROTEIN
18g

CARBS
12g

FAT
13g

FIBRE
0.5g



Selenium

34 µg



Vitamin B12

1.1 µg



Zinc

1.5 mg

Prawns themselves are about 100 kcal per 100 g. Everything above that number arrived in the batter and the fryer.



Chicken Kolhapuri

red masala chicken

1 katori (150 g)

270
KCAL

PROTEIN
24g

CARBS
7g

FAT
16g

FIBRE
1.4g



Vitamin B12

0.6 µg



Zinc

2.1 mg



Iron

1.8 mg

The dry-coconut and chilli masala is calorie-dense but genuinely mineral-rich – not empty fat, which is a distinction worth making.



Pork Vindaloo

Goan vinegar-chilli pork

1 katori (150 g)

345
KCAL

PROTEIN
21g

CARBS
6g

FAT
26g

FIBRE
0.8g



Thiamin

0.7 mg



Vitamin B12

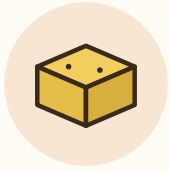
0.8 µg



Zinc

2.6 mg

Pork is the richest common source of thiamin in Indian cooking – one serving covers half a day's need. The saturated fat is the price.



Khaman Dhokla

steamed besan cake

3 pieces (100 g)

160
KCAL

PROTEIN
6.5g

CARBS
22g

FAT
5g

FIBRE
3g

Folate

70 µg

Iron

1.8 mg

Magnesium

40 mg

Steamed, fermented and made of chickpea flour – the rare Indian snack that is high in protein and low in fat at the same time.



Khandvi

besan-curd rolls

4 rolls (80 g)

135
KCAL

PROTEIN
5g

CARBS
14g

FAT
6g

FIBRE
1.8g

Calcium

80 mg

Folate

45 µg

Iron

1.2 mg

Besan plus curd again – complete protein, steamed not fried, and the tempering is the only fat in it.



Fafda

besan strips, fried

40 g

210
KCAL

PROTEIN
5g

CARBS
20g

FAT
12g

FIBRE
2.4g

Sodium

300 mg

Iron

1.3 mg

Folate

40 µg

The same chickpea flour as dhokla, put through a fryer instead of a steamer – roughly double the calories for the same protein.



Sev

fried besan noodles

30 g

175
KCAL

PROTEIN
4g

CARBS
15g

FAT
11g

FIBRE
2g

Sodium

290 mg

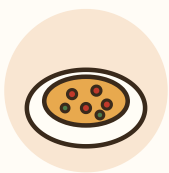
Iron

1.1 mg

Magnesium

26 mg

A garnish that quietly adds 175 kcal to whatever it lands on. Most chaat calories are decided by how generous the sev hand was.



Vada Pav

potato fritter in a bun

1 piece (150 g)

395
KCAL

PROTEIN
8g

CARBS
52g

FAT
17g

FIBRE
3g

Sodium

620 mg

Potassium

350 mg

Iron

1.9 mg

Refined bread around a fried potato: nearly 400 kcal with little protein and a third of the day's sodium. Mumbai's most efficient calorie, for better or worse.



Ukadiche Modak

steamed coconut-jaggery dumpling

2 pieces (80 g)

215
KCAL

PROTEIN
3g

CARBS
34g

FAT
8g

FIBRE
2.4g

Iron

1.4 mg

Magnesium

30 mg

Potassium

160 mg

Steamed rather than fried, and sweetened with jaggery rather than sugar – about as good as a festival sweet gets.



Mohanthal

besan fudge

1 piece (40 g)

205
KCAL

PROTEIN
3.5g

CARBS
24g

FAT
11g

FIBRE
1.2g

Iron

1.0 mg

Magnesium

26 mg

Folate

25 µg

Besan gives it more protein than most sweets; the ghee gives it more fat than most too. The two arrive together.



Kaju Katli

cashew fudge

2 pieces (30 g)

165
KCAL

PROTEIN
3g

CARBS
18g

FAT
9g

FIBRE
0.6g

Magnesium

50 mg

Copper

0.5 mg

Iron

1.0 mg

Cashews carry magnesium and copper worth having, and the fat here is mostly unsaturated – the least objectionable sweet in this book.



Aam Ras

mango pulp, sweetened

1 katori (150 g)

185
KCAL

PROTEIN
1.2g

CARBS
44g

FAT
0.6g

FIBRE
2g

Vitamin A

180 µg RAE

Vitamin C

35 mg

Potassium

260 mg

Real vitamin A and C from the fruit, then sugar and ghee-soaked puri alongside. The mango was never the problem.



Sol Kadhi

kokum and coconut milk

1 glass (200 ml)

110
KCAL

PROTEIN
1.4g

CARBS
9g

FAT
7.5g

FIBRE
0.8g

Potassium

210 mg

Magnesium

26 mg

Vitamin C

6 mg

Kokum is a genuine digestive and cooling agent; the coconut milk is where the calories are. Thinner is better here.

QUICK REFERENCE

West India — twenty more

Everyday dishes from this region in short form. Same serving logic as the data cards: one katori is 150 g of cooked food, one glass 200 ml, and any cooking fat named in the note is already counted in the calories.

FOOD	SERVING	KCAL	PROT	CARB	FAT	FIBRE	NOTE
Bajra Rotla	1 piece, 60 g flour	205	6	36	2.6	6	Iron-dense millet bread
Thalipeeth	1 piece, 80 g	235	7	34	8	5	Multi-grain flour mix
Sabudana Khichdi	1 katori, 150 g	310	3	46	13	1.4	Fasting food; peanut fat
Zunka	1 katori, 150 g	190	8	18	9.5	4.5	Besan; high protein
Pithla	1 katori, 150 g	165	7	16	8	4	Thinner besan version
Bharli Bhendi	1 katori, 150 g	185	3.6	14	12.5	5	Stuffed okra; peanut masala
Batata Bhaji	1 katori, 150 g	175	3	26	7	3	The vada pav filling
Tendli Sabzi	1 katori, 150 g	120	2.4	11	7.5	3.4	Ivy gourd; low GI
Kothimbir Vadi	3 pieces, 80 g	185	6	18	10	3.6	Coriander + besan, steamed then fried
Alu Vadi	3 pieces, 80 g	175	4.5	20	9	3.4	Colocasia leaf; iron
Surti Undhiyu	1 katori, 150 g	240	6.5	24	13.5	7.5	Highest-fibre dish here
Handvo	1 slice, 100 g	210	7.5	28	8	4	Fermented dal-rice cake
Muthiya	3 pieces, 90 g	165	5.5	26	4.5	4.5	Steamed; bottle gourd
Patra	3 rolls, 80 g	165	4	22	7	3.6	Colocasia leaf rolls
Bombil Curry	1 katori, 150 g	175	18	6	9	0.8	Calcium from soft bones
Goan Prawn Curry	1 katori, 150 g	250	18	8	16	1.2	Coconut-heavy gravy
Chicken Xacuti	1 katori, 150 g	295	23	8	19	1.6	Roasted coconut masala
Bebinca	1 slice, 60 g	245	3.5	30	12.5	0.4	Layered egg-coconut cake
Shrikhand Puri	1 plate, 180 g	520	9	62	26	2	Combined plate; calorie dense
Kokum Sherbet	1 glass, 200 ml	85	0.3	21	0.1	0.3	Sugar-sweetened; cooling

Grams of protein, carbohydrate, fat and dietary fibre per serving. Values are rounded and assume home-style preparation; restaurant versions typically carry 20–40% more fat.

REGION FIVE

Central & Northeast India



Forest vegetables, fermented and smoked foods, and millets that never needed rediscovering. Less oil, less sugar and more fermentation than anywhere else in India — and the vitamin K2 and probiotics that come with it.

Grains & Millets

Kodo Millet, Little Millet, Red Rice, Chakhao

Fermented & Smoked Foods

Akhuni, Khorisa, Smoked Pork, Shidal

Forest & Wild Vegetables

Bamboo Shoot, Dhekia Xaak, Kochu Pata, Wild Mushroom

Non-Veg, Sweets & Beverages

Pork with Bamboo Shoot, Duck Curry, Masor Tenga, Til Pitha





Kodo Millet

kodra · varagu

1 katori cooked (150 g)

175
KCAL

PROTEIN
4.5g

CARBS
35g

FAT
1.2g

FIBRE
4.5g

Iron

1.6 mg

Magnesium

68 mg

Zinc

1.1 mg

Grown on land that will not hold rice, and better than rice on almost every measure that matters – fibre, magnesium and glycaemic response.



Little Millet

kutki · samai

1 katori cooked (150 g)

180
KCAL

PROTEIN
5g

CARBS
34g

FAT
1.8g

FIBRE
4.2g

Iron

2.6 mg

Magnesium

60 mg

Phosphorus

130 mg

Twice the iron of white rice for the same calories. Central India's tribal belt has been eating the answer to its own anaemia problem for centuries.



Red Rice

Assam bao dhan

1 katori cooked (150 g)

190
KCAL

PROTEIN
4.4g

CARBS
40g

FAT
1g

FIBRE
2.8g

Iron

1.4 mg

Magnesium

44 mg

Thiamin

0.14 mg

The red bran layer carries antioxidants and most of the grain's minerals – which is exactly the layer polishing removes.



Chakhao

Manipuri black rice

1 katori cooked (150 g)

195
KCAL

PROTEIN
5g

CARBS
40g

FAT
1.4g

FIBRE
3g

Iron

1.8 mg

Magnesium

50 mg

Zinc

1.3 mg

Its colour comes from anthocyanins, the same pigment class as blueberries – the most antioxidant-dense rice grown in India.



Bhutte ka Kees

grated corn, Malwa style

1 katori (150 g)

215
KCAL

PROTEIN
6g

CARBS
28g

FAT
9g

FIBRE
3.4g

Magnesium

50 mg

Folate

45 µg

Vitamin A

40 µg RAE

Fresh corn keeps more folate and fibre than the flour version. The milk it is cooked in adds calcium the dish would otherwise lack.



Bamboo Shoot

khoriya · moya bah

1 katori cooked (150 g)

45
KCAL

PROTEIN
3g

CARBS
6g

FAT
0.5g

FIBRE
3.4g

⚡ Potassium

480 mg

🔵 Manganese

0.4 mg

🟠 Copper

0.2 mg

Very high in potassium, very low in calories, and a genuine prebiotic. Fresh shoots must be boiled and drained – the raw shoot carries cyanogenic compounds.



Dhekia Xaak

fiddlehead fern

1 katori cooked (150 g)

85
KCAL

PROTEIN
4.5g

CARBS
8g

FAT
3.5g

FIBRE
3.6g

🔴 Iron

2.4 mg

🟡 Vitamin A

310 µg RAE

🟠 Vitamin C

20 mg

A foraged green with iron, vitamin A and vitamin C in the same plant – the vitamin C is what makes the iron in it usable.



Kochu Pata

colocasia leaves

1 katori cooked (150 g)

95
KCAL

PROTEIN
4g

CARBS
9g

FAT
4.5g

FIBRE
3.4g

🔴 Iron

2.2 mg

🔵 Calcium

210 mg

🟡 Vitamin A

480 µg RAE

High in calcium and vitamin A, but also in oxalate – which is why it is always cooked with tamarind or lime, not eaten raw.



Wild Mushroom

forest-collected, cooked

1 katori (150 g)

90
KCAL

PROTEIN
4.5g

CARBS
7g

FAT
5g

FIBRE
2.4g

☀️ Vitamin D

1.8 µg

🟠 Selenium

14 µg

⚡ Riboflavin

0.4 mg

One of the only plant foods containing vitamin D at all, and sun-drying them before cooking raises it several times over.



Gongura

roselle leaves · ambadi

1 katori cooked (150 g)

110
KCAL

PROTEIN
3.5g

CARBS
9g

FAT
6.5g

FIBRE
3g

🔴 Iron

2.8 mg

🟠 Vitamin C

42 mg

🔵 Calcium

160 mg

Its sourness is vitamin C and organic acids, sitting in the same leaf as the iron they help you absorb. A self-contained nutritional argument.



Akhuni

fermented soybean · axone

2 tbsp in curry (30 g)

95
KCAL

PROTEIN
8g

CARBS
6g

FAT
4.5g

FIBRE
2.4g

Vitamin K2

35 µg

Iron

1.8 mg

Vitamin B12

0.4 µg

Fermented soybean is one of very few plant foods that produces vitamin K2 and traces of B12 – nutrients otherwise almost exclusive to animal foods.



Khorisa

fermented bamboo shoot

2 tbsp (30 g)

20
KCAL

PROTEIN
1.2g

CARBS
2.5g

FAT
0.3g

FIBRE
1.4g

Potassium

120 mg

Sodium

180 mg

Manganese

0.2 mg

Fermentation removes the raw shoot's toxicity and leaves live lactic bacteria – the Northeast's everyday probiotic.



Smoked Pork

with bamboo shoot

1 katori (120 g)

330
KCAL

PROTEIN
22g

CARBS
3g

FAT
26g

FIBRE
1g

Thiamin

0.6 mg

Zinc

2.8 mg

Vitamin B12

0.7 µg

Smoking preserves without refrigeration, but smoked and cured meats carry compounds best eaten occasionally rather than daily.



Shidal

fermented dried fish

2 tbsp in curry (25 g)

70
KCAL

PROTEIN
11g

CARBS
1g

FAT
2.5g

FIBRE
0g

Calcium

220 mg

Vitamin B12

2.2 µg

Sodium

480 mg

Eaten bones and all, so the calcium is extraordinary for the portion size. The sodium is equally extraordinary – a little goes a long way.



Chhurpi

Sikkim hard yak cheese

20 g piece

75
KCAL

PROTEIN
7g

CARBS
2g

FAT
4.5g

FIBRE
0g

Calcium

180 mg

Vitamin B12

0.5 µg

Phosphorus

120 mg

Protein-dense, shelf-stable for months without a fridge, and chewed rather than eaten – the original high-altitude protein bar.



Pork with Bamboo Shoot

Naga style, boiled

1 katori (150 g)

290
KCAL

PROTEIN
21g

CARBS
4g

FAT
22g

FIBRE
1.6g

⚡ Thiamin **0.6 mg**

💎 Zinc **2.6 mg**

⚡ Potassium **380 mg**

Boiled rather than fried, with almost no added oil – the fat here is the meat's own, and the bamboo adds fibre a meat dish normally has none of.



Duck Curry

Assam, with ash gourd

1 katori (150 g)

285
KCAL

PROTEIN
23g

CARBS
5g

FAT
19g

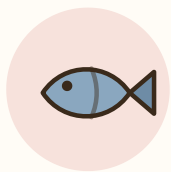
FIBRE
1.2g

🩸 Iron **3.4 mg**

⚡ Vitamin B12 **1.4 µg**

🛡️ Selenium **24 µg**

Duck carries roughly twice the iron of chicken – closer to red meat than to poultry on that count.



Masor Tenga

sour fish curry

1 piece + gravy (150 g)

165
KCAL

PROTEIN
21g

CARBS
5g

FAT
6.5g

FIBRE
0.8g

☀️ Vitamin D **1.8 µg**

⚡ Vitamin B12 **1.6 µg**

🍊 Vitamin C **10 mg**

Barely any oil, soured with tomato or elephant apple – the lightest fish preparation in this book and one of the most nutritionally efficient.



Til Pitha

sesame-stuffed rice roll

2 pieces (70 g)

215
KCAL

PROTEIN
4.5g

CARBS
32g

FAT
8g

FIBRE
2.2g

🧊 Calcium **180 mg**

🩸 Iron **2.2 mg**

🌱 Magnesium **50 mg**

Sesame is one of the densest plant calcium sources there is – this sweet carries more calcium than a glass of milk.



Assam Tea

black, no milk or sugar

1 cup (150 ml)

2
KCAL

PROTEIN
0g

CARBS
0.4g

FAT
0g

FIBRE
0g

⚡ Potassium **35 mg**

🔵 Manganese **0.2 mg**

💧 Fluoride **0.1 mg**

Effectively zero calories, and full of polyphenols – the same polyphenols that block iron absorption. Excellent between meals, poor alongside them.

QUICK REFERENCE

Central & Northeast India — twenty more

Everyday dishes from this region in short form. Same serving logic as the data cards: one katori is 150 g of cooked food, one glass 200 ml, and any cooking fat named in the note is already counted in the calories.

FOOD	SERVING	KCAL	PROT	CARB	FAT	FIBRE	NOTE
Jadoh	1 plate, 180 g	320	14	42	11	1.6	Khasi rice with pork
Eromba	1 katori, 150 g	110	5	14	3.5	4	Fermented fish + vegetables
Singju	1 katori, 120 g	95	4	11	4	4.5	Raw herb salad; very high fibre
Iromba Chutney	2 tbsp, 30 g	35	2	3	1.6	1	Fermented fish base
Kelli Chana	1 katori, 120 g	190	9	28	4.5	8	Steamed chana; Manipur
Chak-hao Kheer	1 bowl, 120 g	215	5	34	6.5	1.6	Black rice; anthocyanins
Zan	1 katori, 180 g	165	4	32	2	3.4	Millet porridge; Arunachal
Thukpa	1 bowl, 250 g	320	15	42	10	3	Noodle soup with meat and veg
Momo (pork)	5 pieces, 150 g	310	14	36	12	2	Steamed, not fried
Gundruk Soup	1 bowl, 200 g	65	3	9	2	3	Fermented leafy greens
Sinki	2 tbsp, 30 g	20	0.8	3	0.2	1.2	Fermented radish tap-root
Poitabhat	1 katori, 200 g	150	3.6	31	0.8	1.4	Assam fermented rice
Khar	1 katori, 150 g	85	3	9	4	2.4	Alkaline preparation; papaya
Pitika (mashed potato)	1 katori, 150 g	145	3	24	4.5	2.6	Mustard oil dressing
Bhaja Moong Dal	1 katori, 150 g	145	9	21	2	4	Roasted moong; Assam
Bora Saul	1 katori, 150 g	200	4	43	0.8	1	Sticky rice; festival grain
Chungapura Fish	1 piece, 120 g	175	21	2	9.5	0	Bamboo-tube cooked; no oil
Dal Bafra	1 plate, 200 g	480	14	62	20	6	Mahwa; ghee-dipped wheat balls
Chakki ki Shaak	1 katori, 150 g	175	7	24	6	3.4	Wheat gluten; Bundelkhand
Mahua Laddoo	2 pieces, 60 g	245	3	34	11	3	Forest flower; tribal staple

Grams of protein, carbohydrate, fat and dietary fibre per serving. Values are rounded and assume home-style preparation; restaurant versions typically carry 20–40% more fat.

BONUS CHAPTER

Twelve claims, checked

Every one of these is repeated daily in Indian kitchens. Each is answered here against the same data used throughout the book — not against opinion.

Rice makes you fat.

MYTH

Gram for gram, rice has fewer calories than roti — 130 kcal per 100 g cooked against 250 for wheat flour. What fills the plate around it, and how much of it you serve, decides the outcome.

Ghee is a health food.

PARTLY TRUE

It is a stable cooking fat and carries fat-soluble vitamins, which matters. It is also 9 kcal per gram and mostly saturated. A teaspoon is sensible; a ladle is marketing.

Paneer is a complete protein substitute for meat.

HOLDS UP

It is a complete protein, with calcium and B12 besides. The catch is fat: 70% of paneer's calories come from it, against 30% for skinless chicken.

Curd with fish or milk with fish is harmful.

MYTH

There is no mechanism and no evidence for this. Coastal cuisines have cooked fish in coconut milk and curd for centuries without consequence.

Brown bread is whole wheat.

MYTH

Most commercial brown bread is refined flour with caramel colour. Read the ingredient list: whole wheat flour must be first, and fibre should be near 6 g per 100 g.

Eating late at night makes you gain weight.

PARTLY TRUE

Total intake over the week is what drives weight. Late eating matters mostly because portions are larger and choices poorer at 11 pm than at 8 pm.

Spinach is the best iron food.

MYTH

Its iron is non-heme and bound to oxalate, so a small fraction is absorbed. Kala chana, bajra and mutton all deliver far more usable iron per serving.

Fruit sugar is fine because it is natural.

PARTLY TRUE

Whole fruit comes with fibre that slows absorption. Juice does not — a glass of sugarcane or mango juice moves blood sugar much as a soft drink does.

Millet is just a fashion.

MYTH

Bajra carries twice the iron of wheat, ragi more calcium than any other cereal, and jowar four times the fibre of maida. The evidence sits in the composition tables, not the trend.

Drinking tea with a meal is harmless.

MYTH

Tea and coffee polyphenols can cut non-heme iron absorption from that meal by up to half. Move them an hour either side and the loss largely disappears.

Fermented food is unhygienic or unhealthy.

MYTH

Fermentation lowers phytate, raises B vitamins and adds live cultures. Idli, dhokla, panta bhaat and gundruk are among the most nutritionally efficient foods in this book.

A vegetarian Indian diet cannot supply B12.

HOLDS UP

Largely true, and it is the most common serious gap on Indian plates. Dairy supplies some; fermented soy a trace. Anyone vegetarian long-term should have B12 tested, not assumed.

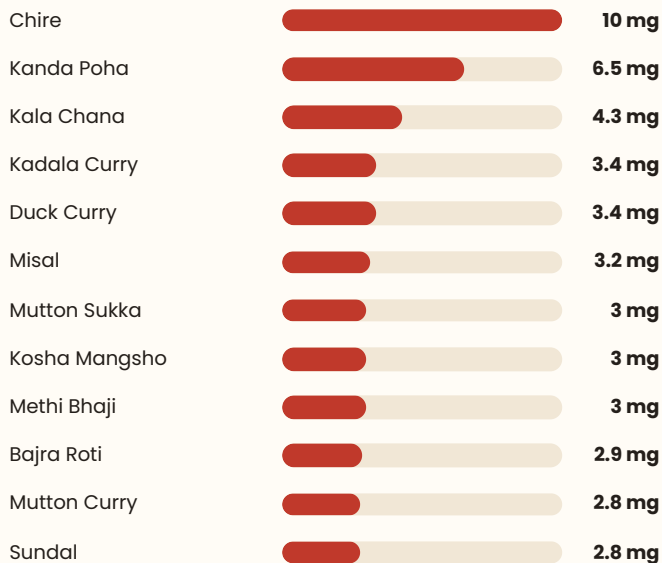
QUICK REFERENCE · 1 OF 2

What to eat for what

Every illustrated food in this book, ranked by what one household serving actually delivers — not by what 100 g of the raw ingredient would.

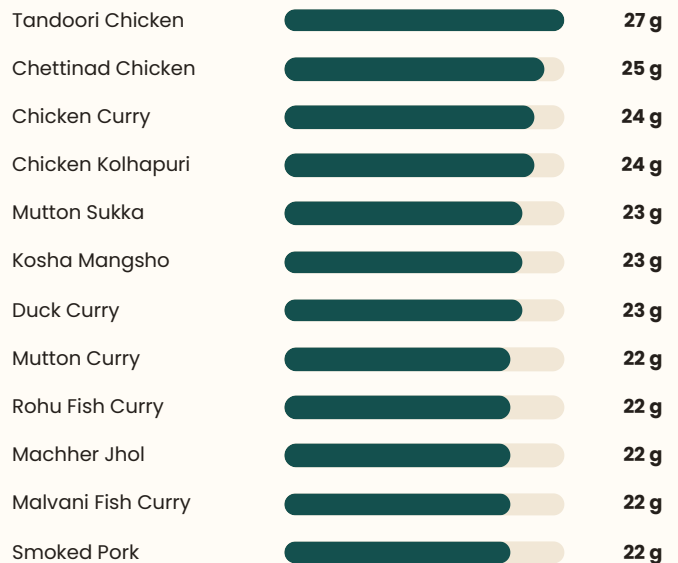
Most iron per serving

milligrams · heme iron absorbs 3–5× better than plant iron



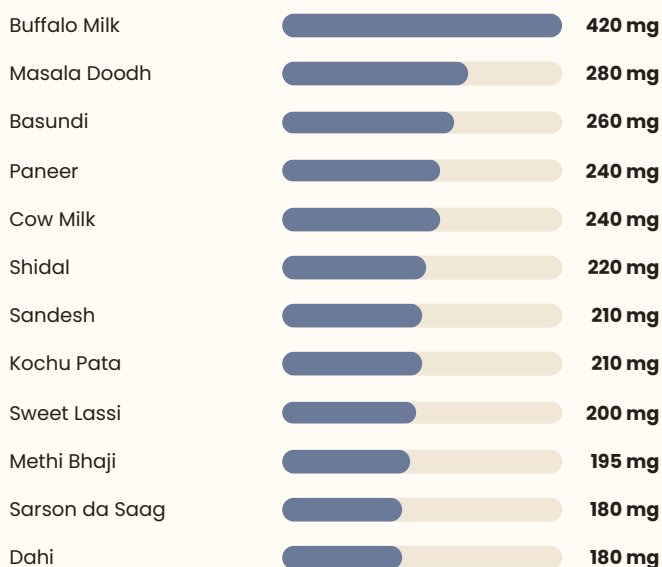
Most protein per serving

grams · animal sources are complete, dal needs grain alongside



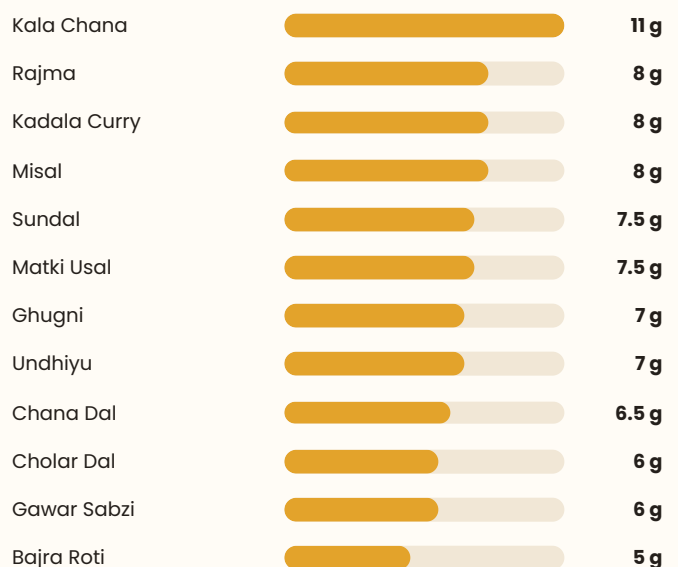
Most calcium per serving

milligrams · adult need is roughly 1000 mg a day



Most fibre per serving

grams · target is 25–30 g a day, most Indians manage 15



QUICK REFERENCE · 2 OF 2

The calorie ladder, and seven swaps

The same information from the other direction: what a serving costs you, and where a small substitution buys the most.

A serving, in calories

household portions, ordered light to heavy

Tender coconut water, 1 nut	45 kcal
Chaas, 1 glass	50 kcal
Rasam, 1 katori	55 kcal
Dahi, 1 katori	90 kcal
Masala chai, 1 cup	90 kcal
Phulka, 1 medium	104 kcal
Toor dal, 1 katori	105 kcal
Idli, 2 pieces	120 kcal
Boiled rice, 1 katori	195 kcal
Samosa, 1 piece	200 kcal
Aloo paratha, 1 large	320 kcal
Vada pav, 1 piece	395 kcal

Lightest dishes in the book

per serving, cooking fat included

Drumstick	45 kcal
Neer More	45 kcal
Tender Coconut Water	45 kcal
Bamboo Shoot	45 kcal
Chaas	50 kcal
Palak	55 kcal
Rasam	55 kcal
Vazhaithandu	60 kcal
Palong Shaak	70 kcal

SEVEN SWAPS WORTH MAKING

Tandoori naan	→ Bajra roti 104 kcal less, 3× the fibre
Sweet lassi	→ Chaas or neer more 130 kcal less, same probiotics
Fafda	→ Khaman dhokla Steamed instead of fried: 50 kcal less, more protein
Boiled white rice	→ Matta or red rice 4× the thiamin and fibre, same calories
Sev on your chaat	→ Sprouted matki Fibre and iron instead of frying oil
Tea with your meal	→ Tea an hour later Up to half the meal's iron kept
Deep-fried medu vada	→ Steamed idli 40 kcal less and 9 g less fat per piece

CLOSING

Where these numbers come from

The primary source is the Indian Food Composition Tables 2017, published by the National Institute of Nutrition, Hyderabad — the measurement of 528 key Indian foods sampled across six regions, and the only composition data built on Indian varieties, Indian soils and Indian cooking.

Where IFCT has no entry — mostly composite restaurant dishes and modern street foods — values are built up from their ingredients using IFCT figures for each, with USDA FoodData Central used for the few ingredients IFCT does not cover.

Servings are households, not laboratories. One katori is taken as 150 g of cooked food, one glass as 200 ml, one medium roti as 40 g of atta before cooking. Cooking fat is stated on the card and counted in the calories.

Rounding. Calories are given to the nearest 5 kcal, macronutrients to one decimal place,

micronutrients to the precision the source supports. Macronutrient grams multiplied out will not always land exactly on the calorie figure — rounding, fibre's partial energy and cooking losses all move it slightly.

What will move these numbers on your own plate: the size of your katori, how much oil the pan actually absorbed, how long a vegetable simmered, and whose hand added the ghee. Read every figure here as a well-anchored estimate for typical home-style cooking, not as a measurement of the meal in front of you.

This book is a reference, not a prescription. Nutrient requirements differ by age, sex, pregnancy, activity level and disease. Nothing here diagnoses, treats or replaces the judgement of a physician or registered dietitian — and anyone managing diabetes, kidney disease, or an eating disorder should read these tables with one.

CITED WORKS

Longvah T., Ananthan R., Bhaskarachary K., Venkaiah K. *Indian Food Composition Tables*. National Institute of Nutrition, Indian Council of Medical Research, Hyderabad, 2017.

U.S. Department of Agriculture, Agricultural Research Service. *FoodData Central*. fdc.nal.usda.gov

Indian Council of Medical Research – National Institute of Nutrition. *Recommended Dietary Allowances and Estimated Average Requirements for Indians*. 2020.

WHAT THIS BOOK DOES NOT CLAIM

Not a diagnosis

No figure here identifies a deficiency. Only a blood test does that, and only a clinician should act on one.

Not a target

Servings describe how Indian households actually eat, not how much anyone should eat. Requirements are personal.

Not exhaustive

India cooks far more than 255 dishes. What is here is the food most often eaten, most often asked about, and most often mismeasured.

WRITTEN BY

Nitin Saxena

What's Actually in Your Thali
First edition · 255 foods · 5 regions